

theatre

Act Won

DELHI A kind of women's renaissance is taking shape slowly, though not silently, in theatre. Two of the most powerful names in contemporary Indian theatre, Amal Allana and Sohaila Kapoor, are staging their plays on July 20, at the India Habitat Centre, and 21, at Epicentre, Gurgaon, respectively. On July 20, the Colombian Embassy will showcase a play *Innocent Erendira And Her Heartless Grandmother*, directed by Allana, who is a roaming ambassador of Indian theatre. This play speaks of a relationship between an adolescent girl and a cruel grandmother, who forces the girl into the flesh trade in order to earn money. Allana has evolved a different kind of magical realism with the help of her most senior cast member, Salima Raza, who adapted it in a mixture of Hindi, Rajasthani and Haryanvi dialects.

The whole story is narrated by the grandmother in Rajasthani. Within a few moments of its opening, it falls into a

rhythm with aesthetically strong visuals. Six actors—Kusum Haidar, Swarupa Ghosh, Natasha Rastogi, Savita Valecha, Shilpika and Raza—make this story engrossing with their stylised movement and narration. To make it a fine blend of Indian and Latin American cultures, Allana takes the help of her husband and production designer, Nissar Allana. But the real beauty lies in its superb acting and firm grip on the story.

Playwright, actor and director Kapoor's play *Ouch* revolves around three young women aspiring to become television anchors. Based on German playwright Lutz Hübner's *Creeps*, *Ouch* actually shows the desperation of these girls—named Jojo, Poornima and Meenu—to get into the mainstream. In the process, they commit comical mistakes and expose themselves during their interviews. But jokes aside, it hits on a raw nerve in these times of media overload. *Ouch* uses very contemporary and colloquial language. With the acting prowess, dance, music and video, it becomes quite a performance.

by Sheekesh Mishra

DRAMATIC RECLUSE: Actors performing Allana's play



art

Passion of the Palette

KOLKATA Sandip Roy and his fascination with landscapes will be on view for art lovers at Akar Prakar Gallery from July 10 to 23. Roy's work has won him critical acclaim within a few years and he is now recognised as one of the most promising new artists. His attachment to nature is evident when he paints the hills of Kedarnath and the beaches of Dighe. He uses watercolours for most of his landscapes and the bold strokes make them come alive. He delicately uses the transparency of these colours to explore the relations between man and nature. His *Evening in Benaras* and *Benaras at Night* are stunning, with the colours of the ghats becoming vibrant with the clever use of light and shade. And along with the landscapes are stark images of modern times that portray men and women performing their daily chores and children taking in the little joys of life among its hardships.

by Elora Sen

COLOUR SPECTRUM : *Evening in Benaras* by Roy



music

Soulful Harmony

KOLKATA Two artistes come together to celebrate the monsoon season. Vocalist Jagdish Prasad, from Patiala gharana, was a pupil of Badri Prasad, his father, and later of Bade Ghulam Ali Khan. Jagdish's music is a unique blend of emotional expression and technical craftsmanship, which makes his performance scintillat-



Biswajit Roy Chowdhry

ing. This will be followed by a sarod recital by Biswajit Roy Chowdhry, a pupil of Mallikarjun Mansur and Amjad Ali Khan. At Vivekananda Hall, on July 17.